Chichen Itza

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Chichen Itza is a major archaeological site associated with Maya civilization in the Yucatan Peninsula of Mexico. It contains monumental architecture reflecting religious, political, astronomical, and cultural practices.

Location

Chichen Itza is located in the northern part of Mexico's Yucatan Peninsula. The site developed in a region where water availability was strongly influenced by natural limestone formations and underground water sources.

History

Chichen Itza became an important regional center during the later part of the first millennium CE. Its history includes influences associated with different Maya and Mesoamerican traditions.

El Castillo

The most famous structure is El Castillo, also called the Temple of Kukulkan. It is a stepped pyramid with four stairways leading toward the upper temple.

Kukulkan

Kukulkan is a feathered serpent deity associated with Maya traditions. The architecture of El Castillo has been connected with calendrical and astronomical observations.

Astronomy And Calendar

Maya civilization developed sophisticated systems for observing celestial bodies and measuring time. Some architectural alignments at Chichen Itza are associated with astronomical cycles.

Great Ball Court

Chichen Itza contains one of the largest known ancient Mesoamerican ball courts. The ball game was an important cultural practice in several Mesoamerican societies.

Sacred Cenote

The site includes a large natural sinkhole known as the Sacred Cenote. Cenotes were important water sources in the Yucatan and could also have religious significance.

Architectural Features

Other structures include the Temple of the Warriors, the Group of a Thousand Columns, and the Observatory, commonly called El Caracol.

Modern Significance

Chichen Itza is a UNESCO World Heritage Site and became one of the New Seven Wonders of the World in 2007.

Key Retrieval Terms

Mexico, Yucatan, Maya civilization, Chichen Itza, El Castillo, Kukulkan, ball court, Sacred Cenote, astronomy, Mesoamerica.